

LIGHT COIN

*A game of silver, short weight,
and a currency everybody needs and nobody trusts*

5 PLAYERS • 12 ROUNDS • 75 MINUTES

*No single light coin can be told from a good one.
No single light coin makes anybody poorer.
The coinage fails all the same.*

1 The Coin

Your city mints its own money, and each of the five great Houses holds the right to strike it. A coin is worth what it weighs in silver, and it passes from hand to hand all day long because everybody trusts that it does.

You can strike a light coin. A little less silver, the same face stamped on it, the difference too small for anybody to feel in their palm. Every House can do this, and the profit is immediate.

One light coin harms nobody. Nor does a hundred. But coin circulates, and light coin circulates faster, and there comes a point at which the traders begin weighing rather than counting, and then refusing altogether. When that happens the money is worthless in every purse in the city, including yours.

The difficulty is that a purse of coin tells you how much silver is missing but never which House it came from, nor whether your own full-weight striking on any particular day was the thing that kept the money good.

The shape of the game

You win by accumulating Profit, and striking light is the fastest way to accumulate it. But if Trust reaches zero before the twelfth round, *every player loses, including whoever was winning*. The game is an argument about how much bad silver the city can absorb, conducted by people who cannot check each other's work.

2 Components

20 white cubes	Truth. Four per player each round.
20 black cubes	Light coin. Four per player each round.
1 Melt bag	Opaque. Claims go in here.
1 Silver bag	Refilled to 16 white and 4 black cubes each round.
5 cups	Opaque. Conceals your retained striking cube.
5 tubes	Opaque, capped, just wider than a cube. Your striking record, stacked in order. Never opened until the end.
5 screens	Or simply play below the table edge.
Trust track	0 to 40, with tiers marked at 31, 21 and 11.
1 round log	A shared sheet. Everything public gets written down.
20 Discredit tokens	Red. Kept in public view.
1 Standard card	With five membership slots.
10 Warning tokens	Two per player.
5 player aids	The challenge table, reproduced at the back.
1 First Player marker	Passes clockwise each round.

3 Setup

1. Set the Trust marker to 36.
2. Give each player one white and one black cube, one cup, one tube, one screen and one player aid.
3. Put 16 white and 4 black cubes in the Silver bag. Leave the Melt bag empty.
4. Nobody scores anything yet. Profit is not paid out during the game; it is reconstructed at the end. Rule up the round log with a column for each round.
5. Give the First Player marker to whoever most recently signed something without reading it.

4 The Round

Twelve rounds, five phases each. The first two matter more than they look, because they are what stops anybody working out who did what.

Phase 1. The Striking

Behind your screen, take one white and one black cube in a closed fist. The Melt bag passes in seat order. Reach in, release *exactly one* cube, and withdraw your fist still closed.

Release black to strike light. Release white to strike full weight.

Then, in full view, place the cube still in your hand under your cup without showing it. That retained cube is the exact opposite of the one you played, and it is now the only proof of what you did.

Do this before you touch the Silver bag

Both cubes must be committed, one in the melt and one under the cup, before anybody draws silver. A player still holding a cube when the silver comes round can swap the two, and a House that struck light has every reason to gamble on it.

Phase 2. The Silver

The Silver bag holds sixteen white cubes and four black. It passes in seat order.

Reach in, take *one cube without looking at it*, and drop it straight into the Melt bag with your hand closed.

You will never know what you contributed. Neither will anybody else. Roughly one round in five your silver came in adulterated, and there is no arrangement under which you could have refused it, declared it, or been believed about it afterwards.

Why you are not allowed to look

If you knew what you had drawn, you would have every reason to hold the black back and put a white cube in instead. Bad silver erodes Trust, and Trust is your money. Every House would reason the same way, no adulterated metal would ever reach the melt, and with it would go the uncertainty that makes an assay a judgement rather than an arithmetic exercise.

Phase 3. The Count

Tip out the Melt bag. Count the black cubes aloud. That number is the round's Light Count.

It counts both deliberate short weight and bad silver nobody ordered, and there is no way to tell how the total divides between them.

Phase 4. The Assay

Beginning with the First Player and going clockwise, the first player who wishes to may call one assay, and only one assay is called per round in total.

You may only call an assay if you released a white striking cube this round.

Name a House and demand their coin on the scales. They lift their cup.

Light White under the cup means they played black. They lose this round's Profit and take a Discredit. The challenger gains 3 Profit.

Sound Black under the cup means they struck full weight. *The challenger* takes a Discredit.

A House taking its third Discredit is ruined and out of the game.

Why only the honest may accuse

You cannot demand that others put their coin on the scales in a round in which your own was short. Policing therefore has a price: to be able to call an assay at all, you must give up the round's larger payout.

Phase 5. Erosion and Reset

Reduce Trust by the Light Count.

Then, without showing it to anybody, drop your retained striking cube into your tube and replace the cap. Cubes stack in the order they go in, so your tube is a record of every round in sequence. It is black if you struck full weight this round and white if you struck light, and it went under the cup before you touched anything else, so it cannot be anything but the truth.

Return the melt to the supply, refill the Silver bag to sixteen white and four black, redistribute one white and one black cube to each player, and pass the First Player marker clockwise.

Why nothing is paid out during the game

Striking full weight pays 2 and striking light pays 6, so reaching for your money would tell the table exactly what you had done. Nobody takes Profit during a round. Everything public goes on the round log, your one private choice goes into your tube in order, and the two are put together at the end when secrecy no longer costs anything.

Your tube must hold exactly twelve cubes at the close, one for each round. A tube holding any other number has been tampered with.

The round log

One player keeps it, in full view, and everybody can correct it. Each round, record: the Light Count, the new Trust total and therefore the tier, who called an assay, whom they named, and what was found. Also note who is in the Standard.

Every one of those is something the whole table watched happen. Only your own striking stays private, and only until the last round is over.

5 Profit

Score your action immediately in Phase 2, according to the current tier.

Trust	Full weight	False claim	Premium
36 to 31	2	6	4
30 to 21	2	5	3
20 to 11	2	4	2
10 to 1	2	3	1
0	<i>the coinage collapses; everybody loses</i>		

The premium for lying shrinks as the coinage degrades. Light coin is most profitable when the city can least afford it and barely worth the risk once the damage is done, which is the opposite of what everybody's instincts will tell them.

6 Reading the Count

You know the Light Count, and you know whether your own striking cube was black. Subtract it if so. The result is the Remainder, which contains the other four Houses' strikings and all five silver draws, including your own unknown one.

Remainder	Chance any given House lied
1	19%
2	37%
3	52%
4	65%
5	76%
6	84%

Below a Remainder of 3, challenging is usually a poor bet. Above 4 it is close to a duty. Between the two, it depends entirely on what you think of the person you are looking at.

Remember that a bad shipment of silver puts a black cube in the melt exactly as deliberate short weight does. A House that was sold adulterated metal is indistinguishable from one that clipped its coin on purpose, and can never prove otherwise.

7 The Standard

At any time between rounds, three or more players may sign the Standard: a public undertaking to strike full weight, checked against a shared set of scales.

Dividend Members gain +1 Profit each round, paid whatever they struck. The Standard pays for belonging, not for behaving, because paying for behaviour would reveal it.

Tariff Non-members pay 1 Profit to the bank each round. Trade on the city's terms costs more when you have not signed up to them.

Threshold The Standard only functions with three or more members. At two, all benefits cease at once.

A member caught light by assay is sanctioned in steps, never all at once.

First A Warning token.

Second The dividend is withheld for two rounds.

Third Expulsion, and the seat cannot be reclaimed.

Size decides everything

With exactly three members, any single departure destroys the Standard for everybody, so every member holds a veto and knows it. With four, one may leave and it survives. The same act carries entirely different weight depending on how many are standing beside you.

8 Ending the Game

The game ends after the twelfth round, or immediately if Trust reaches 0.

If the coinage collapses, every player loses, including any who were eliminated earlier and any who were comfortably ahead.

Otherwise, uncap the tubes. Everybody empties theirs at the same time, and the cubes come out in order, last round first.

Work through the round log together, round by round, reading each player's cube for that round against the tier that was in force. Nothing here is private any more, and nothing has to be taken on anybody's word.

Full weight A black cube. Score 2, plus 3 banked for having struck sound.

Light A white cube. Score the false-striking rate for that round's tier: 6, 5, 4 or 3.

Caught A round in which you were assayed and found light scores you nothing. The log says which round it was.

Assays called 3 for each one you called correctly.

Standard +1 for each round you were a member, and -1 for each round you were not. +5 if it is still standing at the end.

Highest total wins. A player eliminated by Discredits scores nothing, whatever is in their tube.

On winning

Nobody knows the scores until the tubes come out, which is the point. The winner is usually somebody who struck full weight most rounds, called an assay or two, and was believed. The second most common winner is somebody who lied twice, very early, and was never challenged for it. Both should feel earned.

PLAYER AID

The round

1. Striking. Fist into the melt, release one. Retained cube under the cup *now*.
2. Silver. One cube from the Silver bag, *unseen*, straight into the melt.
3. Count. Black cubes aloud.
4. Assay. One only, and only if you struck full weight.
5. Erosion. Trust drops by the Count. Retained cube into your *tube*, cap on.

Reading the count

Remainder = Light Count minus your own striking cube, if it was black.

Remainder	1	2	3	4	5	6
Struck light	19%	37%	52%	65%	76%	84%

Below 3, a poor bet. Above 4, close to a duty.

At the cup

WHITE under the cup	they played black. They lied.
BLACK under the cup	they struck full weight.

Payouts

Trust	36–31	30–21	20–11	10–1
Honest	2	2	2	2
False	6	5	4	3

Assay correctly: they lose the action and take a Discredit; you gain 3.
Assay wrongly: you take the Discredit. Three Discredits and you are ruined.